

JBL Tour One M3

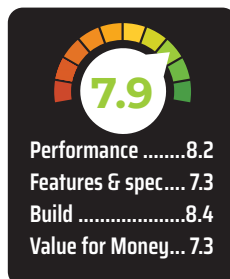
Good sound and smart features that come at a price

While picking a high-end headphone, you know you can expect a certain quality of audio and a set of features. With the JBL Tour One M3, too, you get hi-res LDAC wireless audio, lossless sound via USB-C cable, Spatial 360 sound with Head Tracking, 8-mic-powered adaptive noise cancelling, smart ambient modes, a very long battery life claim, and a very similar appearance to the previous Tour One. JBL also bundles an intriguing piece of hardware with its new Tour headphone, dubbed Smart TX. It is a Bluetooth transmitter with a screen that lets you quickly control several features of the headphones. So, while I started reviewing the headphones to test how useful Smart TX is, I enjoyed using the product for reasons beyond that.

DESIGN

The regular JBL Tour One M3 arrives in Black, Mocha, and Blue colours. The Smart TX edition ditches the Mocha variant. Our review unit is the blue Smart TX one. The colour of the box matches the colour that you pick, along with some signature orange accents. Inside, there is a similarly coloured hard-shell carry case that is pear-shaped. It is compact and sturdy enough to be durable and portable. It has a standard zip, which feels reliable even if it lacks the magnetic closing you see on some higher-end models like the Sony WH-1000XM6.

Opening the case shows earcups that rotate and fold flat. The box includes a USB-C to USB-C cable, a 3.5 mm audio cable, and, if you buy the Smart TX bundle, JBL's Smart TX transmitter with a USB-A to USB-C converter. The Smart



TX unit weighs 34.5 g, has a small rectangular body, and fits in your palm. You turn it on with a button on top. A single tap on this button switches the screen on or off. It has USB-C ports on both ends, one for charging and the other for a wired connection to a source device. Unlike a simple USB dongle, it includes a compact touchscreen that lets you adjust playback, ANC, EQ, calls, and other headphone settings without using your phone. It also works as a USB-C or 3.5 mm transmitter that can broadcast audio over Auracast to compatible devices.

As for the headphones, they take the Tour One M2 design and refine it. They have a matte finish that looks clean without trying too hard. Build quality is solid, using reinforced plastic with metal inside the headband. At 278 g, they feel light and mostly comfortable. The padding is soft, and the clamp is

mild, but the oval pads and the fit can start to feel uneasy during long sessions.

Controls are a mix of buttons and touch gestures. The buttons/slider for power and pairing work fine, and I always appreciate the tactility of physical controls. The touch panel responds well to your commands as well. You can't remap or change these control functions, but JBL gives you options to toggle them off completely.

FEATURES & CONNECTIVITY

The pairing process is smooth with Android thanks to Google Fast Pair, and standard Bluetooth pairing works without fuss on other platforms. Once paired, download and open the JBL Headphones app. The app takes a second to connect to the device, but once it does, you get a feature-rich and easy-to-use UI.

This is the app to control the settings of both the One M3 and Smart TX. The app gives access to Personi-Fi 3.0 for hearing-based tuning, a customizable 10-band EQ, the option to toggle LDAC, Smart Talk (that lowers playback volume when you start speaking), spatial sound with head tracking, ANC controls, auto play/pause, voice-aware settings, multipoint, and even a Relax Mode (that plays relaxing mixes of sounds like waves, bonfire, wind, trees rustling, and many more).

The app also lets you manage the Smart TX transmitter. It connects to most devices through USB-C or 3.5 mm, including in-flight screens, older laptops, consoles and TVs. It supports Bluetooth LE Audio, LC3 and Auracast, so that it can send higher-quality audio with lower latency than many built-in Bluetooth chips. You can control volume, noise cancellation or ambient mode, Spatial Sound, the equaliser, the timer and LDAC directly from the touchscreen on the dongle when your phone is not nearby. You swipe between screens and tap to confirm a setting.

CLEAR & CONSISTENT AUDIO

The Tour One M3 uses 40 mm Mica Dome drivers and supports LDAC, LC3,